

Department of Philosophy
MA Exam / PhD Qualifying Exam: Ancient Philosophy 2019

Answer exactly three questions from the following sections, with no two questions from the same section. In each case, you should defend your claims as well as you can and make your answers as detailed as possible. You have two hours for the entire examination, so you should devote approximately 40 minutes to each answer.

I. Socrates

I.1 What is the relationship among knowledge, virtue, and happiness according to Socrates? What reasons does Socrates have for his view of their relationship?

I.2 Socrates has been charged with contributing to philosophy a style of mistaken thinking, known as the Socratic Fallacy. How plausible is this charge? Defend your answer.

I.3 In various places throughout Plato's early dialogues Socrates claims to be ignorant. Some have taken these claims to be sincere, while others have taken them to be ironic. Critically discuss what you take to be the most plausible interpretation of these claims, making sure to explain how you would respond to the most serious objections to the interpretation you choose.

II. Plato

II.1. It has been claimed that Plato's theory of Forms has a certain philosophical economy. What does such a claim mean and how plausible is it?

II.2. Critically evaluate one of Plato's arguments in any of the dialogues for the immortality of the soul.

II.3. In Republic IV Plato puts forward a definition of justice in the city and justice in the individual. What are these definitions? Critically evaluate Plato's arguments on their behalf.

III. Aristotle

III.1. Critically discuss Aristotle's doctrine of natural teleology. What is it and how plausible is it? Defend your answer.

III.2. Present and discuss Aristotle's view of whether future-tensed sentences – e.g., "There will be a sea battle tomorrow – are truth-evaluable. What hangs on Aristotle's view of this matter in respect of fatalism?

III.3. Critically evaluate the claim that Aristotle's conception of happiness, and hence his eudaimonistic ethical theory, depends on his theory of the soul and the human soul in particular.

IV. Miscellaneous – Ancient Greek and Roman

IV.1. Discuss the difference the Stoics would identify between that which is classified as a) good, b) preferred indifferent, and c) dispreferred indifferent. How are these classifications

applied with respect to desires and what is their intended impact on Stoic accounts of well-being in relation to reason.

IV.2. Discuss the “symmetry argument” Lucretius offers in support of the Epicurean conclusion that “death is nothing to us.” In your discussion, identify and describe one significant critique of this argument.

V. *Analects*

1. The *Analects* emphasizes what might be called the “style” of our actions more than is common in moral philosophy. E.g., Confucius claims that being filial entails managing one’s facial expressions. Give an account that explains this emphasis, both why it is important and what complications it raises.

2. The ethics of the *Analects* is often described as particularistic, yet the text is also clearly committed to endorsing a thoroughgoing adherence to *li* 禮. How might the tension between employing practical judgment and following *li* rather strictly be reconciled?

3. Many contemporary interpreters seek to align the *Analects* with a rather standard account of virtue ethics. Provide an assessment of whether virtue ethics does indeed well map any moral theory implicit in the *Analects*.

VI. Mengzi

1. In *Mengzi* 1A7, Mengzi claims to have identified a “sprout” of goodness in a king who has spared an ox from ritual slaughter. Explain the basis for Mengzi’s claim, both what would constitute a “sprout” and what the presence of such a sprout is meant to indicate regarding human nature.

2. Key to any success Mengzi’s claim regarding the goodness of human nature will enjoy is providing an adequate explanation of moral failure. That is, if we are to believe that “human nature is good” in the way that Mengzi intends, we shall also require an account of why so many human beings in fact fail to be moral. Provide an overview of Mengzi’s account of moral failure and assess its adequacy as support for his view of human nature.

VII. Xunzi

VII.1. Xunzi’s view of human nature, that it is “bad” (*e* 惡), sometimes tempts interpreters into a psychologized reading in which Xunzi features as the “pessimistic Confucian.” This reading is, however, complicated by where Xunzi’s ethics ultimately concludes: with sages who defy nature to become exquisitely moral. Discuss Xunzi’s account of human nature and subsequent “solution” to the problems it poses with reference to pessimism. Is Xunzi’s a pessimistic morality?

VII.2. Xunzi’s account of ritual has been viewed as providing a distinctive response to situationist challenges in ethics. The response relies on Xunzi’s strong endorsement of external supports (principally in the form of *li*) as a key element in both individual moral development and social moral communities. Describe just how Xunzi’s account of *li* can be understood as a potentially effective response to situationism and critically evaluate its suitability on this score.

VII.3. Xunzi's presentation of the basis for ritualized mourning can be seen as responsive to criticisms that mourning is "unnatural" in a way that ill-serves human psychological, emotional, and ethical needs (e.g., the sort of critique Zhuangzi offers). How well does Xunzi's justification of ritualized mourning address these critiques?

VIII. Zhuangzi

VIII.1. What is the role of humor in the style of argument Zhuangzi provides? In what way is couching reasoning in humor and even mockery methodologically important for the text's substantive views?

VIII.2. The Butcher Ding story in the *Zhuangzi* is often deployed as offering a *leit motif* for the text as a whole, with Butcher Ding's description of his development of excellence in carving viewed as sketching the human developmental trajectory Zhuangzi endorses. However, as Robert Eno has argued, there is no unambiguous indication in the text that morality need be part of human development - in Eno's vivid presentation, no reason Butcher Ding couldn't be carving a person. Is the *Zhuangzi* as amoral as this suggests? Provide a case for treating the *Zhuangzi* as incorporating moral considerations or sensibilities.

VIII.3. The "philosophical methodology" of the *Zhuangzi* (if such a thing can be said to exist) is radically distinctive, freely employing fantastical story, comic jibes, and wildly non-standard exemplars. Provide an account that explains how the aesthetic and methodological oddity of the text functions as *part of* the text's arguments.

IX. Miscellaneous: Chinese Philosophy

IX.1. Commentators such as Edward Slingerland have argued that *wuwei* 無為 operates, minimally, as a point of convergence or, maximally, as a unified focus, in most of early Chinese philosophy. Evaluate this claim. Does it overstate the significance of *wuwei* or endorse a stronger likeness across texts and philosophers than is warranted?

IX.2. The *Mozi* employs precedent as one of its three criteria, or gauges, for evaluating the worth of claims. Critically evaluate the *Mozi*'s use of precedent, considering whether it represents a genuine criterion, a nod to conventional argument style in early China, or collapses into a consequentialist standard.